



BEFORE

Both sides in the Civil War recognized that control of the Mississippi River was a major strategic objective. The Union held Cairo, Illinois, at the confluence of the Mississippi and Ohio, but the Confederates hoped to prevent them from advancing farther south.

CONFEDERATE MOVES

In September 1861, Confederate troops under General **Leonidas Polk** seized **Columbus on the Mississippi** in Kentucky. He turned it into a **fortress with 143 guns** trained on the river, which was blocked by a chain. This **"Gibraltar of the West"** presented a **formidable obstacle to any Union advance** down the Mississippi.

However, after the **fall of Fort Donelson in February 1862** (see [Grant Takes Forts Henry and Donelson](#)), Columbus was abandoned without a fight, rendered untenable by the threat to its supply lines. Part of the garrison and many of its guns were relocated 50 miles (80km) south at **Island Number Ten**.

UNION STRATEGY

On February 23, 1862, the **Union commander in the Western theater, General Henry Halleck**, ordered the creation of the **Army of the Mississippi**. With 25,000 men under Major General John Pope, the army's task was to **advance down the Mississippi River** in cooperation **with the river fleet**.

At the outset of the Civil War, the Anaconda Plan proposed by Union general-in-chief Winfield Scott gave priority to an advance down the Mississippi to cut the Confederacy in two. Whether considered desirable or not, such an offensive was not immediately possible because it required the creation of a Union river fleet that could cooperate with the army to overcome the Confederate fortresses dominating the waterway. For the construction of a flotilla of ironclad river gunboats, the Union turned to engineer and industrialist James Eads. He built seven vessels from scratch to a design by Samuel Pook, a naval architect based in Cairo, Illinois. They were shallow-draft ships driven by a paddlewheel at the stern and enclosed in sloping iron armor. Officially called City-class gunboats, they were better known by their nickname: Pook Turtles.

The seven ironclads formed the core of the Western Gunboat Flotilla, initially under U.S. Army control. The Confederates, in contrast, had to make do with adapting riverboats into ships of war, usually by adding cotton bales as armor—making them “cottonclads”—then reinforcing the prow with iron to make a ram, and by arming them with one or two guns.